Fewer Students, Emptier Classrooms

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Across the United States, public school classrooms are getting emptier and the reasons are piling up. For years, fewer babies have been born, which means fewer children showing up for kindergarten. Los Angeles County is a clear example. Its huge school district, the second largest in the country, has lost more than 300,000 students over the last two decades. Nationwide, the number of children under 18 began falling after 2010, dropping by about 2.1 million through 2025. Public school **enrollment** peaked in 2019 and had fallen by roughly 1.5 million students by the 2024 school year. Federal researchers project at least 2 million more students will be lost by 2030. Now a second force is adding to the decline: **immigration enforcement**. A study by the Migration Policy Institute found that as many as 1.9 million people left the United States during the first 18 months of President Trump's second term. In Los Angeles, school board member Kelly Gonez said her district had predicted a 2 percent **enrollment** drop, but the real drop was double that. She said many families went into hiding after raids stepped up in 2025. The pattern shows up in other states, too. Texas lost more than 76,000 students last year, mostly Hispanic children and children of immigrant families. In Florida, the Miami-Dade and Broward County **districts** together lost about 30,000 children in a single year. In California's Central Valley, student absences jumped more than 20 percent in communities hit by raids. Researchers say this is the first time in nearly a century that low birth rates and low immigration have hit at the same time. One report warned that **enrollment** declines are already reshaping **districts** in 40 states and could cost public schools about 11 billion dollars a year in funding. The White House has said **deportations** make classrooms less crowded, while supporters of tighter immigration say the school system is not promised a set number of students. Either way, **districts** are now facing hard choices. Los Angeles has begun a process to identify **campuses** that may close, and Gonez expects the cuts to be deep.

Word Treasure

enrollment -- Enrollment is the number of students signed up to attend a school.

immigration enforcement -- Immigration enforcement is when the government carries out laws about who can live in a country.

deportations -- Deportations happen when the government makes people leave a country.

campuses -- Campuses are the buildings and grounds of a school.

districts -- Districts are areas of schools grouped together under one local school system.

Background you need

Public schools are schools run by local districts and paid for with public money, and they serve the children who live in their area.

When fewer children are born, fewer children later start kindergarten, so classrooms slowly become emptier over time.

Immigration enforcement can also affect enrollment, because some families may move away or keep their children home when they are afraid.

When enrollment falls, a school district receives less funding and may have to make hard choices about keeping campuses open.

Break it down

LEAD: Public school classrooms across the United States are getting emptier as fewer children are born and immigration enforcement drives families away.

KEY EVENT: Public school enrollment peaked in 2019 and had fallen by roughly 1.5 million students by the 2024 school year.

+- WHO: Students in public schools nationwide, including in Los Angeles, Texas, Florida, and California's Central Valley

+- WHEN: The decline has built over two decades, with the number of children under 18 falling after 2010 and further losses projected by 2030

+- CAUSE 1: Fewer babies have been born, so fewer children are showing up for kindergarten

+- CAUSE 2: Immigration enforcement -- as many as 1.9 million people left the United States during the first 18 months of President Trump's second term

EVIDENCE: Los Angeles predicted a 2 percent enrollment drop but the real drop was double that, and student absences jumped more than 20 percent in Central Valley communities hit by raids

CONSEQUENCE: Districts face hard choices, including possible campus closures in Los Angeles, and enrollment declines could cost public schools about 11 billion dollars a year in funding

OPEN QUESTION: How will districts handle shrinking enrollment and funding while deciding which campuses to keep open?

Why it matters

Shrinking enrollment is already reshaping school districts in 40 states, forcing decisions about closures and funding that affect what classes, teachers, and programs students can count on.

Test what you remember

1. **How many students has the Los Angeles school district lost over the last two decades?**
   - (A) About 76,000 students
   - (B) More than 300,000 students
   - (C) Roughly 1.5 million students
   - (D) About 30,000 students
2. **According to the article, when did the number of children under 18 in the United States begin falling?**
   - (A) After 2030
   - (B) After 2019
   - (C) After 2025
   - (D) After 2010
3. **How many more students do federal researchers project public schools will lose by 2030?**
   - (A) About 11 billion
   - (B) About 76,000
   - (C) About 30,000
   - (D) At least 2 million
4. **What did the Migration Policy Institute study find about people leaving the United States?**
   - (A) About 2.1 million people left through 2025
   - (B) About 30,000 people left in a single year
   - (C) As many as 1.9 million people left during the first 18 months of President Trump's second term
   - (D) More than 76,000 people left last year
5. **Which group made up most of the more than 76,000 students Texas lost last year?**
   - (A) Hispanic children and children of immigrant families
   - (B) Children in California's Central Valley
   - (C) Children in Los Angeles County
   - (D) Children in the Miami-Dade and Broward County districts
6. **According to one report cited in the article, how much funding could enrollment declines cost public schools each year?**
   - (A) About 2 billion dollars
   - (B) About 30,000 dollars
   - (C) About 11 billion dollars
   - (D) About 1.9 billion dollars

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: D 3: D 4: C 5: A 6: C

Questions to think about

1. **The White House: Said deportations make classrooms less crowded.**
2. **Supporters of tighter immigration: Say the school system is not promised a set number of students.**

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):